

THE MONEY HEALING SERIES

# The Minimalist Budget

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*Spend Less, Stress Less, and Still  
Have a Life*

## Disclaimer

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Results mentioned are illustrative only. Individual circumstances vary significantly. The publisher assumes no liability for actions taken based on information in this book.

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# Why Most Budgets Fail

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*A budget that makes you miserable doesn't fail because you're undisciplined. It fails because it was designed wrong.*

## The Deprivation Model Problem

Traditional budgeting treats every spending category as a target to hit exactly and every overage as a failure. This creates a cycle of guilt, restriction, rebellion, and shame that most people can't sustain for more than a few weeks.

The minimalist budget works differently: instead of tracking every category, you identify your non-negotiable joys, protect them, and reduce friction everywhere else.

You're not cutting until it hurts. You're cutting until you can't tell the difference — and leaving the things you'd genuinely miss completely intact.

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*"A budget should free you, not cage you."*

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# The Reverse Budget

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*Pay yourself first, spend the rest freely. It sounds too simple to work. It works.*

## How It Works

On payday, immediately transfer your savings target to a separate account. Immediately pay your fixed bills (rent, utilities, debt minimums). Whatever remains is yours to spend freely, without tracking, until the next payday.

This works because the important money is moved before discretionary spending can reach it. You're not relying on willpower to save — you're saving first and spending what's left.

Start with 10% savings if your budget allows. If it doesn't, start with \$50. The habit is more important than the amount.

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*"Pay yourself first and stop counting the rest."*

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# Finding the Fat Without the Pain

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*Most households have \$300-\$700/month of spending they genuinely wouldn't miss. Finding it is the whole game.*

## The Subscription Audit

List every recurring charge: streaming services, subscriptions, app purchases, memberships, SaaS tools, automatic renewals. Most households have between 12 and 18 of these, and most people can't name more than six.

Cancel everything you haven't used in 30 days. Pause anything you use occasionally but not regularly. Keep only what you'd notice being gone.

The average household saves \$150-\$300/month doing this audit once. It takes 90 minutes. Do it now.

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*"The money you're wasting is in the subscriptions you forgot about."*

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# Food: The Biggest Variable

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*Food spending is the most controllable major expense and the most emotionally loaded.*

## The Middle Path

Extreme food budgeting — rice and beans every night, never eating out — is sustainable for almost no one. It also misses the point. Food is pleasure, culture, connection, and sustenance. Eliminating joy from eating to save money is a bad trade.

The middle path: cook the majority of your meals at home, eat out intentionally rather than habitually, and apply the 24-hour rule to food delivery (most late-night delivery orders are boredom, not hunger).

Meal prep one day per week eliminates the 6pm 'I don't know what to make and I'm exhausted' decision that drives the majority of unnecessary food spending.

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*"Eat out for joy. Not for convenience."*

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# Housing and Transportation: The Big Levers

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*These two categories represent 50–70% of most people's budgets. Small changes here dwarf everything else.*

## The Housing Calculation

The standard guideline is to spend no more than 30% of gross income on housing. Many people in high cost-of-living areas exceed this significantly, which constrains every other financial goal.

If housing exceeds 35% of your income, it's worth evaluating: roommate options, geographic flexibility, proximity-versus-cost tradeoffs, and the full costs of homeownership versus renting in your specific market.

Housing decisions are the highest-leverage financial decisions most people make. They deserve more than a weekend of thought.

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*"Where you live is a financial decision before it's a lifestyle one."*



# Building a Life You Don't Need to Escape From

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*The best financial plan is one that funds a life you actually want.*

## Aligning Money and Meaning

The minimalist budget is not about having less. It's about being intentional about what you spend on — and eliminating the rest to free up money and mental space for what actually matters to you.

Write down the 10 things that bring you the most genuine satisfaction. Look at where your money goes. Build a budget that funds the list. Cut what isn't on it.

This is not asceticism. It's clarity. And clarity about what you value is the foundation of a financial plan that you'll actually keep.

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*"Spend more on what you love. Spend nothing on what you don't."*

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